

LA.2 Permit Application Checklist

Everything to gather before you file — and the code editions, deadlines and thresholds that decide what you are filing for.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Louisiana writes one mandatory construction code for the whole state and then hands enforcement to each parish and municipality, which is why the code your house must meet is the same in Cameron Parish as in Caddo while the office that inspects it, the forms it hands you and the fee it charges are not. Confirm every local item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

THE CODE THAT BINDS YOUR HOUSE

Louisiana runs a single mandatory construction code for the entire state. Every parish and every municipality enforces the same technical requirements; what varies is the office, the forms and the fee. The editions below are what was in force when this kit was verified.

Code editions in force in Louisiana

Code	Edition	Effective	Notes
International Residential Code — your house	2021	1 January 2023	Adopted without Part I (Administrative) and without Part VIII (Electrical) — and those two exclusions do more work than anything else in this table. Everything else is in, including Part VII, the plumbing chapters . Appendix AQ, Tiny Houses, is adopted; Appendix J at your parish's option.
International Building Code	2021	1 January 2023	Not your house — 1- and 2-family dwellings use the IRC.
International Mechanical Code	2021	1 January 2023	HVAC.
International Plumbing Code	2021	1 January 2023	Not your house. A one- or two-family dwelling plumbs to IRC Part VII , which Louisiana adopts and amends heavily — see below. The IPC covers the buildings the IRC does not.
International Fuel Gas Code	2021	1 January 2023	Gas piping and appliances.
International Existing Building Code	2021	1 January 2023	Work on existing structures.

Code editions in force in Louisiana

Code	Edition	Effective	Notes
International Energy Conservation Code	2021	mid-2023	The IECC came in months after the rest of the package, and the Commission's own publications disagree on the day — its edition sheet says 1 July 2023, a Louisiana Register citation in the same document says 1 August 2023. If a date matters to you, get it from your permit office in writing.
National Electrical Code	2020	1 January 2023	The NEC governs your wiring directly, because Part VIII of the IRC is not adopted. Louisiana amends several articles, including 210.8 and 210.52(C).

Editions and adoption text: LAC Title 17, Part I, Chapter 1, §§103–117 (each section captioned “Formerly LAC 55:VI.301.A...”), as compiled by the Louisiana Uniform Construction Code Commission, Building Code Adoption & Inspector Licensing Law and Rules and Regulations, 1 August 2026. Effective dates: the Commission's published construction-code history sheet, revision of 6 August 2026. Both are free at lsuccc.la.

The most valuable date in this kit: 1 January 2027

Louisiana does not inspect your house against whatever code happens to be current when the inspector shows up. It inspects against the code that was in force when you *applied*. The rule is one sentence: a licensed inspector “shall conduct a building inspection using **the codes in effect for the locality on the date of the application for the original building permit.**”

And Louisiana's next code cycle is already scheduled. The Commission approved adoption language for the **2024 I-Codes** and the **2023 NEC** at its meeting of 7 July 2026, and the approved rule text carries an effective date of **1 January 2027**.

Put those two facts together. **An application filed before 1 January 2027 would lock your house to the 2021 I-Codes and the 2020 NEC for the life of the build** — through a framing inspection that may not happen until 2028. An application filed after it would not. If you are near that line, the date you file is a design decision and a budget decision, not paperwork.

Treat the date as scheduled, not settled. Approved language is not yet promulgated law: the rule still has to complete the Administrative Procedure Act process and legislative oversight and appear in the *Louisiana Register*, and no such publication had appeared when this kit was verified. Code cycles slip. Ask your permit office which editions they are enforcing on the day you file, and get the answer in writing — that written answer, with your application date, is what R.S. 37:3734 protects.

Code-date rule: La. R.S. 37:3734, “Codes applicable to building inspections,” enacted by Acts 2026, No. 881. Next-cycle editions and date: the Commission's construction-code history sheet, revision of 6 August 2026, and its published notice of the 2023 NEC and 2024 I-Code adoption.

The statute number changed on 1 August 2026 — almost nothing has caught up

Until this year Louisiana's construction-code law lived at **R.S. 40:1730.21 and following**, run by the Louisiana State Uniform Construction Code *Council*. **Acts 2026, No. 881** moved the whole program into **Title 37, Chapter 62 — R.S. 37:3727 through 3750** and renamed the body the Louisiana Uniform Construction Code *Commission*. Section 5 of that Act repealed R.S. 40:1730.21 through 1730.40.2 **“in its entirety.”**

So every Louisiana building-code citation you will find in guides, older kits, parish handouts and code-adoption trackers points at **repealed law**. This kit prints the live numbers. Expect to meet the old ones anyway — several parish permit pages still cite the retired state web address, let alone the retired statute.

One warning if you go to check. At the time this kit was verified the Legislature's own database at legis.la.gov had not reloaded: it still served the repealed Title 40 sections as though live, and returned nothing at all for a Title 37 lookup. That is a database lag, not a legal fact. Read the Act itself, or the Commission's compiled volume, rather than the statute browser.

Acts 2026, No. 881 (House Bill No. 1186), 2026 Regular Session: enacts Chapter 62 of Title 37 comprised of R.S. 37:3727 through 3750, and by Section 5 repeals R.S. 40:1730.21 through 1730.40.2. Effective 1 August 2026 — confirmed by the Commission's own editor's note to its 2023 NEC and 2024 I-Code adoption language.

TWO THINGS NO PARISH MAY REQUIRE OF YOU

Both are worth knowing before you walk in, because both save real money and both are occasionally asked for anyway.

No stamped plans for a prescriptive house

“Notwithstanding any law to the contrary, a municipality or parish shall not require that a residential building plan for a one- or two-family dwelling be prepared or stamped by a licensed architect or engineer if that dwelling falls within the prescriptive standards of the International Residential Code currently adopted in the Uniform Construction Code.”

La. R.S. 37:3737(D). Read the condition carefully: it protects a house built **within the IRC's prescriptive standards**. Step outside them — a long clear span, an unusual foundation, an engineered wind detail — and you are back to needing a design professional. In much of south Louisiana the foundation alone will take you there.

No residential fire sprinklers — and no local ordinance may add them

“The commission shall not adopt or enforce any part of the International Residential Code or any other code or regulation that requires a fire protection sprinkler system in one- or two-family dwellings. **A municipality or parish shall not adopt or enforce an ordinance or other regulation requiring a fire protection sprinkler system in one- or two-family dwellings.**”

La. R.S. 37:3733(A)(3), carried into the code itself as the Louisiana amendments to 2021 IRC Sections R313.1 and R313.2. If you install one voluntarily it must be built to R313 — the amendment says so — but nobody may make you.

And one thing a parish may only do with the Commission's permission

R.S. 37:3748(E): “If a governing authority or any municipality or parish finds that the state minimum standards do not meet its needs, **the local government may with approval of the commission provide requirements more stringent than those specified by the state.**” A parish can be stricter than the state code — but not on its own say-so.

And an inspector cannot invent stringency at the counter. R.S. 37:3747(A)(11)(a) makes each of these **a violation of the authority of the commission**: “(i) Enforcing a code requirement in an area or circumstance not specified in that requirement. (ii) Enforcing a requirement in a manner that is **more stringent than or exceeding the code requirement.** ... (iv) Enforcing a code official's preference in the method or manner of installation if that preference is not required by the Uniform Construction Code or contradicts a manufacturer's installation instructions or specifications.”

That is a real remedy, and worth knowing exists before you need it. Ask politely which code section a demand comes from. If there is no section, you now know what the statute calls that.

THE AMENDMENT THAT CHANGES HOW YOU FRAME

Most of Louisiana's amendments to the IRC are administrative. One is not, and it is the single biggest technique and cost difference between building here and building to the unamended code. Louisiana rewrote the wall-bracing section:

Louisiana amendment to 2021 IRC Section R602.10, Wall Bracing

“In Climate Zone 2A, one and two family dwellings shall be continuously sheathed with a minimum 7/16" wood structural panels (Table R602.10.4 CS-WSP), or it's structural equivalent as per an ICC-ESR and approved by the local building official.”

Every parish in Louisiana is Climate Zone 2A, so this is every house in the state.

Continuous structural sheathing is mandatory — let-in bracing, portal-frame-only and gypsum-only bracing methods are off the table. Price the whole wall in sheathing from the start; discovering this at framing inspection is expensive.

Three smaller amendments in the same family, each of which an inspector will look for: a **6 mil** ASTM E1745 Class A vapor retarder under the slab (amended §R506.2.3); **ring-shank roof-sheathing nails** required wherever wind design is required, with the plain 8d common nail allowed only where it is not (amended Table R602.3(1)); and no climate exemption from decay-resistant lumber — Louisiana struck the IRC's exception, noting in the rule itself that the committee “felt the State of Louisiana did not have such a geographical region to preclude.”

Louisiana amendments to 2021 IRC Sections R602.10, R506.2.3, Table R602.3(1) and R317.1, LAC 17:I.107. Climate zone: Louisiana amendment to 2021 IECC Section C301.2.

FLOOD: THE FREEBOARD ANSWER MOST GUIDES GET BACKWARDS

You will read, in a great many places, that Louisiana deleted its statewide freeboard requirement and left elevation entirely to the parishes. That is not what the code in force says. Louisiana's own amendment to the IRC sets a **floor** that a parish may exceed and may not go under.

Louisiana amendment to 2021 IRC Section R322 — flood construction

“Buildings and structures constructed in whole or in part in flood hazard areas, including A or V Zones and Coastal A Zones, as established in Table R301.2, ... shall be designed and constructed in accordance with the provisions contained in this section. Buildings and structures that are located in more than one flood hazard area shall comply with the provisions associated with the most restrictive flood hazard area. Buildings and structures located in whole or in part in identified floodways shall be designed and constructed in accordance with ASCE 24-14. **The local jurisdictions, utilizing flood plain managers, shall have the authority to adopt higher freeboard amounts as needed (CRS, etc.) but shall not have the authority to adopt freeboard amounts less than those required in ASCE-24-14”**

The elevation your lowest floor must reach is therefore set by **ASCE 24-14**, a referenced standard, applied through your parish's floodplain manager — and it varies with your flood zone and the building's flood design class. This kit prints no number for it, because the number is in a copyrighted standard and depends on facts about your lot. **Ask your floodplain manager, in writing, for the required lowest-floor elevation for your parcel**, and ask separately whether the parish has adopted freeboard above the ASCE 24-14 minimum. Many have; the Community Rating System rewards it.

*Louisiana's amendment to IRC Section R322, LAC 17:I.107. **Cite it by the quoted text, not the sub-number:** the Office of the State Register's LAC heads this amendment R322.2.1 and the Commission's compiled volume heads the identical text R322.1. Separately, R.S. 37:3738(B)(3) provides that for residential construction “the standards published by the Federal Emergency Management Agency for the National Flood Insurance Program apply.” Two independent routes to the same conclusion: elevation is not optional and it is not purely local.*

One practical consequence worth planning for: an **elevation certificate** prepared by a surveyor is what documents compliance, and most parishes want one before the final. Budget for it, and get the surveyor booked early — after a storm season they are the bottleneck in south Louisiana.

WIND, AND THE ONE CLIMATE ZONE

Louisiana's design wind speeds are among the highest in the country and they vary sharply with distance from the coast. The kit prints no parish-by-parish wind table, because the governing figure comes from the IRC's own wind speed map and its ASCE references as applied to your site, and a table transcribed from a secondary source is exactly the kind of number that gets a house built wrong. **Get the design wind speed and the wind-borne debris determination for your parcel from your permit office in writing**, and put both on your plans.

The energy side is simpler than anywhere else in the country, and this one *is* a flat statewide answer. The Louisiana amendment to the 2021 IECC reads, in full: **“All parishes in Louisiana shall be Climate Zone 2A warm humid climates.”** One zone, whole state — so every IECC table you use is the same row from Shreveport to Venice, and the design problem is cooling, humidity and air sealing rather than insulation depth.

Louisiana amendment to 2021 IECC Section C301.2, as printed in the Commission's compiled rules, 1 August 2026 (LAC 17:I.117).

IF YOU ARE NOT ON PUBLIC SEWER: START HERE, AND START EARLY

The sewage permit is the longest pole on most rural Louisiana builds and it is a **state** permit, not a parish one — it comes from the state health officer, delivered through your local parish health unit, which is a state office rather than parish government. It issues in two stages, and the first stage has to be approved before you install anything.

The two-stage individual sewage permit

Stage 1 — temporary permit	Authorizes the installation. Issued only after the state health officer has determined that connection to a community sewerage system is not feasible and that soil, drainage, lot size and dimensions will support a system. Valid one year ; ask for an extension if the build slips.
Stage 2 — final permit	Issued after installation is verified, by an on-site inspection and/or a “Certification by Installer” form. If you installed it yourself you are not a licensed installer, so plan on the inspection.
The application document	LHS-47 , Application for Permit for Installation of On-Site Wastewater Disposal System. It is filled out at the parish health unit — it is not a blank download.
Before backfill	Nothing may be covered until the sanitarian has verified the installation. Notify the office 24 hours ahead of expected completion.
Why the final approval matters later	LDH's own applicant form notes that lenders and government agencies will not approve loans or refinancing on a residence with no record of final approval. Skipping it creates a financing problem, not just a compliance one.

LAC 51:XIII.701.A, B and C; LHS-47 named in rule at LAC 51:XIII.731.D and 733.C.8; inspection, notice and validity from LDH forms SF-10ST (rev. 07/25) and the Office of Public Health's Information Packet for Applicants.

Three rules that decide whether you may install it yourself

1. You must do the actual installation. LDH's form SF-10ST states the exception plainly: “The property owner (permit holder) may install a septic tank (non-mechanical) system for their own personal use **only if the property owner does the actual installation.**”

2. You may not hire an unlicensed helper for any part of it. Same form: “Hiring an unlicensed person to perform any part of the installation of your septic tank will not be allowed under this exception and the system in question will not be approved by this office.” The instinct to borrow a neighbor with a backhoe forfeits the exemption.

3. A mechanical plant is off the table. An individual mechanical plant — the aerobic treatment unit Louisiana leans on wherever soils and water tables defeat a conventional field — must be installed and maintained by a licensed installer (LAC 51:XIII.705.A). And because the Sanitary Code's reduced lot sizes are themselves conditioned on using a mechanical plant, a small lot can push you off the self-install path without anyone telling you.

The lot-size gate — check this before you buy

Louisiana sets a statewide minimum lot size for a home on an individual sewage system, and it is stricter than most people expect. These are the criteria the state health officer applies when deciding whether an individual system may be used at all.

Minimum lot size for a home on an individual sewage system

	Requirement	Citation
Baseline for a single lot	22,500 sq ft minimum area and 125 ft minimum frontage.	LAC 51:XIII.511.B.4
Large lots	One acre or more, with 125 ft frontage.	LAC 51:XIII.511.B.3
Where the parish runs a formal sewage permitting system	22,500 sq ft / 80 ft frontage; or 16,000 sq ft / 80 ft with a mechanical plant ; or 12,000 sq ft / 60 ft with a mechanical plant followed by 50 ft of modified absorption field.	LAC 51:XIII.511.B.6
Design flow ceiling	The individual-system route assumes total anticipated design flow not exceeding 1,500 gpd.	LAC 51:XIII.511.B.2

Read the third row carefully: the smaller lot sizes are available only in parishes whose governing authority “has enacted and enforces a formal sewage permitting system,” and two of the three require a mechanical plant — which you may not install yourself. Whether your parish qualifies is a question for the parish, and the answer changes what you may build on a small lot.

IF YOU ARE ON A PRIVATE WELL

The well is the mirror image of the septic system, and getting this backwards is expensive.

Private water wells

Permit before drilling?	No. A domestic well needs no pre-drilling permit statewide.
May you drill it yourself?	No. “All water wells, regardless of use or type” must be drilled or constructed by a contractor licensed by the department — LAC 56:I.307.A. Reworking, plugging and abandonment too. This is the exact opposite of the septic rule.

Private water wells

Notification	For a domestic well in a non-critical ground water area, a notification form goes in within 60 days after installation — and the driller's own 30-day registration satisfies it. Registration is the contractor's legal duty, not yours.
Casing depth, private supply	Not less than 10 ft below ground surface.
Casing height	At least 12 inches above ground level; in flood-prone areas at least 2 ft above the highest flood level of the last ten years, and never less than 2 ft above grade.
Grouting, private supply	Cemented from a minimum depth of 10 ft to the ground surface.

*Licensed-driller requirement: LAC 56:I.307.A and B. Notification: LAC 43:VI.701.C. Registration duty: LAC 56:I.105.A. Construction numbers: LAC 51:XII.327.A.6, A.7 and A.8. **One agency-name warning:** the program now sits with the Department of Conservation and Energy, which was the Department of Energy and Natural Resources until 1 October 2025 and the Department of Natural Resources before that. The rule text still names older agencies in places — LAC 51:XII.327.A.14 still says “Louisiana Office of Public Works.” Follow the agency, not the printed name.*

THE TWO ENVIRONMENTAL PERMITS PEOPLE MISS

Neither is a building permit and neither comes from your parish, which is exactly why they get missed.

- **Construction stormwater.** If your project will disturb **one acre** or more — and clearing, grading and the driveway all count — you are into LDEQ's construction stormwater general permit and a notice of intent. On a large rural lot this is easier to trigger than people expect.
- **Treated sewage discharge.** If your system will discharge treated effluent to the surface rather than to a subsurface field, LDEQ's sanitary discharge general permit is in play. The Sanitary Code says so itself: individual systems other than a conventional septic tank with subsurface disposal “shall comply with all provisions of the Louisiana Department of Environmental Quality Wastewater Discharge Permit” (LAC 51:XIII.703.B).

There is a third permission that is not a permit at all: if your effluent will reach a roadside ditch on a state highway, that is the state highway department's ditch, and you need its consent. Ask before you design the outfall — a rejected outfall can change the entire system type.

THE APPLICATION CHECKLIST

Work this with a pen. The items in the first block are the ones Louisiana adds to what any state would ask for.

Louisiana-specific items

	Item	Date	Where obtained / reference
☐	Affidavit Claiming Exemption from Licensure , LSLBC form, notarized, all eleven statements initialed. Latest revision checked.		
☐	Confirmed with the permit office whether my site is in the unincorporated parish or inside a municipality.		
☐	Design wind speed for the parcel, obtained in writing, and shown on the plans.		
☐	Wind-borne debris determination for the parcel, obtained in writing.		
☐	Flood zone and required lowest-floor elevation from the parish floodplain manager, in writing; parish freeboard above the ASCE 24-14 minimum confirmed separately.		
☐	911 address assigned and posted visibly at the property.		
☐	Sewage: LHS-47 temporary permit issued (or public sewer connection confirmed available).		
☐	Property plat with a surveyor's seal or a Clerk of Court "true copy" certification.		
☐	Driveway tie-in: state highway department permit if fronting a state route; parish permit if a parish road.		

The usual application items

	Item	Date	Where obtained / reference
☐	Completed building permit application.		
☐	Site plan showing structures, distances to property lines, well and sewage system.		
☐	Construction plans. No architect or engineer seal required if the house is within IRC prescriptive standards.		

The usual application items

	Item	Date	Where obtained / reference
☐	Proof of ownership with the legal description — deed, bill of sale, act of donation.		
☐	Termite pretreatment arrangement.		
☐	Energy compliance documentation, 2021 IECC, Climate Zone 2A.		
☐	Written contracts signed with every licensed subcontractor before any work begins.		
☐	License verification printouts for every sub, from the board's database.		

PERMIT RECORD

Fill this in as each permit issues, and keep it with the job. The expiry column matters more in Louisiana than most states — your sewage temporary permit runs one year.

Permits and approvals on this project

Permit or approval	Issuing office	Number	Issued	Expires
Building permit				
Sewage — temporary permit (LHS-47)				
Sewage — final permit				
Electrical permit				
Plumbing permit				
Mechanical permit				
Driveway / culvert				
LDEQ stormwater (if 1 acre or more)				
LDEQ discharge (if surface discharge)				
Certificate of occupancy				

Permits and approvals on this project

Permit or approval	Issuing office	Number	Issued	Expires

Sources — every Louisiana claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Code editions adopted, and the parts of the IRC excluded	LAC 17:I.103-117 (formerly LAC 55:VI.301.A)
Effective dates, and the scheduled 1 January 2027 next cycle	LUCCC edition sheet rev. 6 Aug 2026; approved rule text, 7 Jul 2026
Inspections use the codes in force on the original application date	R.S. 37:3734, enacted by Acts 2026, No. 881
No architect or engineer stamp for a prescriptive IRC house	R.S. 37:3737(D)
No residential sprinkler mandate, and no local override	R.S. 37:3733(A)(3); LA amendments to IRC R313.1, R313.2
Flood construction and the ASCE 24-14 freeboard floor	LA amendment to IRC R322, LAC 17:I.107
NFIP standards apply to residential construction	R.S. 37:3738(B)(3)
The whole state is Climate Zone 2A	LA amendment to 2021 IECC C301.2
Two-stage sewage permit from the state health officer	LAC 51:XIII.701.A, B, C
Owner may install a non-mechanical system, personally, with no unlicensed help	LAC 51:XIII.705.A; LDH form SF-10ST item 1
Nothing covered before the sanitarian verifies	LDH form SF-10ST item 4
Minimum lot area and frontage for an individual system	LAC 51:XIII.511.B.2, .3, .4, .6
Water wells must be drilled by a licensed contractor	LAC 56:I.307.A, B
Domestic well notification within 60 days after installation	LAC 43:VI.701.C
Well casing depth, height and grouting for a private supply	LAC 51:XII.327.A.6, A.7, A.8
Non-conventional systems fall under the LDEQ discharge permit	LAC 51:XIII.703.B

Everything cited here is free to read. A **R.S.** citation is a Louisiana Revised Statute — search the number at **legis.la.gov** under Louisiana Laws. A **LAC** citation is the Louisiana Administrative Code, published as free PDFs by the Office of the State Register at **doa.la.gov**. Rules newer than the last codified printing appear only in the Louisiana Register at the same site, so check there before relying on a date. Read September 2026.